THE CLUB

by Molly Baz

Au Poivre Creamed Greens with Crispy Walnuts

SERVES: 8

In my opinion, the best part about dining at a classic steakhouse is never the steak but the many sauces on offer to accompany it. Let's be honest, the meat itself is usually kinda mid, so a great sauce does all the heavy lifting. My personal favorite? Au poivre, the spicy, peppercorn-flecked French cream sauce that adds richness and luxe to anything it touches. This particular iteration of au poivre is not a sauce per se, but a base for creamed greens, my #1 go-to order when it comes to steakhouse sides. You'll use frozen and thawed spinach (kale or other greens would work great too), and cook them down in cream with tons of garlic with a hefty glug of cognac until they melt away into au poivre oblivion. Crispy black peppered walnuts are the topper here because what your Thanksgiving meal almost certainly needs is a little more crunch!

ACTIVE + TOTAL TIME: 25 MINS

PRODUCE

- 1 head garlic
- 1 yellow onion

PANTRY

- Kosher salt
- 2 tablespoons coarsely ground black pepper
- 1 tablespoon whole fennel seeds or 2 ½ teaspoons ground
- 1 cup cognac or dry sherry
- 1 ½ cups walnuts
- 2 tablespoons sherry vinegar or Dijon mustard

DAIRY

- 7 tablespoons unsalted butter
- 2 ½ cups heavy cream

FROZEN

- 32 ounces frozen spinach and/or kale

1. THAW THE GREENS:

- Place 32 ounces frozen spinach in a large colander and run warm water over it for a few minutes, until most of the ice crystals have melted. Let sit in the strainer and continue to thaw while you do the rest of your prep.
- Finely chop 1 onion.
- Lightly smash and peel the cloves from one head of garlic, setting aside one clove for the walnuts. Thinly slice all the rest.
- Using a mortar and pestle or spice grinder, grind enough fennel seed to measure 2 ½ teaspoons ground (start with about a tablespoon and see how you do).

2. COOK THE GREENS:

- In a medium skillet, melt 4 tablespoons of butter over medium. Add the onions,

garlic and 2 tablespoons of freshly ground black pepper (grind it into a small bowl and measure from there). Season with 1 teaspoon salt and cook, stirring occasionally, until the onions are very soft and juuuust beginning to turn golden at the edges, but not burnt, 9-14 minutes. Stir in the ground fennel.

- While the onions cook, squeeze out as much liquid as possible from the thawing spinach.
- Once the onions are cooked, add 1 cup cognac or dry sherry, increase the heat a bit and cook until mostly evaporated but the onions are still a little saucy, about 3-6 minutes.
- Stir in 2 ½ cups cream, the wrung-out spinach, and 1 ½ teaspoons salt. Bring to a simmer, cover with a lid, reduce the heat to medium and cook, stirring once halfway, 7-9 minutes. Remove the lid, and continue to cook until the cream has thickened and reduced substantially and the liquid is no longer watery. (If using kale, you likely won't have to reduce any further.)
- Remove from heat, and season to taste with 1-2 tablespoons sherry vinegar or a big dollop of Dijon mustard (both work great, use what you've got!). Taste and adjust for seasoning–you'd be surprised how much salt these guys need. Cover to keep warm. You can gently reheat before serving. (Greens can be made up to 2 days in advance)

3. MAKE THE CRISPY WALNUTS:

- Finely chop 1 ½ cup walnuts.
- In a small skillet, melt the remaining 3 tablespoons butter over medium. Add the walnuts, and a bunch of big cranks of pepper and cook, stirring constantly, until the walnuts are toasted and golden all over, about 5-9 minutes. Remove from heat, and finely grate 1 large garlic clove into the skillet, stir to coat. Transfer to a small bowl and season with salt. (Walnuts can be made up to 2 days in advance.)

4. WHEN READY TO SERVE:

- Gently reheat the greens in a skillet or pot over medium low heat.
- Taste and re-season if needed. Transfer to a serving dish, and top with the crispy walnuts.

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